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ADVANCED INJURY SIMULATION OF GAME CHARACTERS

POKROČILÁ SIMULACE ZRANĚNÍ HERNÍCH POSTAV

BACHELOR'S THESIS
BAKALÁŘSKÁ PRÁCE

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BRNO 2026

BRNO UNIVERSITY OF TECHNOLOGY
FACULTY OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

Bachelor's Thesis Assignment

172352

Institut:	Department of Computer Graphics and Multimedia (DCGM)
Student:	**Helešic Adam**
Programme:	Information Technology
Title:	**Advanced Injury Simulation of Game Characters**
Category:	Computer Graphics
Academic year:	2025/26

Assignment:

1. Familiarize yourself with game development in the Godot engine.
2. Study the issue of game character animation and damage during combat.
3. Research existing and possible solutions to the given problem.
4. Design a user interface and the final functionality of an application that demonstrates advanced character reactions to injuries.
5. Implement the application and demonstrate its use with different types of data.
6. Perform user or performance testing of the results.
7. Document and publish the final application.
8. Create a video representing the results of your work.

Literature:

- Adams, Ernest, and Joris Dormans. Game mechanics: advanced game design. New Riders, 2012. ISBN 0321820274, 9780321820273.
- Geijtenbeek, T., Vasilescu, D., Egges, A. Injury Assessment for Physics-Based Characters. In: Allbeck, J.M., Faloutsos, P. (eds) Motion in Games. MIG 2011. Lecture Notes in Computer Science, vol 7060. Springer, Berlin, Heidelberg. 2011. DOI: 10.1007/978-3-642-25090-3_7.
- Francis Laclé, Nicolas Pronost. Real-Time Musculoskeletal Model for Injury Simulation on 3D Human Characters. Motion In Games Conference (MIG), Nov 2012, Rennes, France.
- Aristidou, A., Lasenby, J., Chrysanthou, Y. and Shamir, A. Inverse Kinematics Techniques in Computer Graphics: A Survey. Computer Graphics Forum, 37: 35-58. 2018. DOI: 10.1111/cgf.13310.

Requirements for the semestral defence:
Items 1-4, experiments leading to item 5.

Detailed formal requirements can be found at https://www.fit.vut.cz/study/theses/

Supervisor:	**Chlubna Tomáš, Ing., Ph.D.**
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Beginning of work:	1.11.2025
Submission deadline:	13.5.2026
Approval date:	7.11.2025

Abstract

Do tohoto odstavce bude zapsán výtah (abstrakt) práce v anglickém jazyce.

Abstrakt

Do tohoto odstavce bude zapsán výtah (abstrakt) práce v českém (slovenském) jazyce.

Keywords

Sem budou zapsána jednotlivá klíčová slova v anglickém jazyce, oddělená čárkami.

Klíčová slova

Sem budou zapsána jednotlivá klíčová slova v českém (slovenském) jazyce, oddělená čárkami.

Reference

HELEŠIC, Adam. *Advanced Injury Simulation of Game Characters.* Brno, 2026. Bachelor's thesis. Brno University of Technology, Faculty of Information Technology. Supervisor Ing. Tomáš Chlubna, Ph.D.

Advanced Injury Simulation of Game Characters

Declaration

Prohlašuji, že jsem tuto bakalářskou práci vypracoval samostatně pod vedením pana X... Další informace mi poskytli... Uvedl jsem všechny literární prameny, publikace a další zdroje, ze kterých jsem čerpal. Pro jazykovou revizi technické zprávy jsem použil(a) nástroj ChatGPT. Při tvorbě odevzdaného programového kódu jsem využíval nástroj Github Copilot. [konkretizujte a upravte podle skutečnosti].

.....
Adam Helešic
May 4, 2026

Acknowledgements

V této sekci je možno uvést poděkování vedoucímu práce a těm, kteří poskytli odbornou pomoc (externí zadavatel, konzultant apod.).

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Chapter 1

Introduction

The goal of this thesis is the design and implementation of a dynamic injury system of game characters in the Godot Engine. The term *character* here describes game characters in general, and is not intended to be limited to anthropomorphs. This demo is not player-centric, but rather aims to implement a standalone injury system and its effects on the creature's behavior and animation.

Chapter 2 explores existing injury systems from a design perspective and explains the basics of the mechanisms that are used in the implementation of the final product, which include inverse kinematics (for character animation) and AI patterns (specifically the finite state machine and the behavior tree).

Chapter 3 details the design of the game demo. It explains the design of the enemy model, the subsystems necessary for implementing a cohesive enemy with a specialized injury system.

Chapter 2

Game Character Injury Systems and Animation

Combat and injury have been a part of human history even since prehistoric times. Physical conflict accompanies many stories, large-scale historical events, and even modern times. It is then no wonder that games have used this theme in a myriad of ways. From mythical, heroic combat with swords and magic to competetive shooters, countless games had to contend with designing and implementing combat and injury systems.

Each game has its budget and own set of priorities based on their design. Sometimes, developers may decide to prioritize other parts of the game like visuals, story, and voice acting over the implementation of complex combat systems, opting for greater abstraction. The easiest systems are the ones that model characters as a singular entity with no subparts and a number representing hit points that determines its binary state – alive or dead. However, other designs call for a more complex and varied experience.

This chapter delves into the basics of game design and examines how other games have developed such systems. Next, it looks into the mechanisms constituting an advanced injury system of game characters – systems of simulating harm and injury, locomotion, and enemy artificial intelligence (AI) that reflects the injuries in its decision making.

2.1 Game Design

Game design is the act of deciding what a game should be. Decisions about rules, look and feel, timing, pacing, risk-taking, rewards, punishments, and everything else the player experiences is the responsibility of the game designer [5]. Schell proposes a very player-centric definition – *anything* that the player experiences in the game is part of the game design. It is a fair, but broad explanation. A lower level approach may be more useful in practice when creating a new design.

Adams and Dormans argue that games are built on a set of rules that together define the play experience. There are a few principles to designing rulesets. Firstly, a game should have an extent of unpredictability (but not be too unpredictable nor a predetermined sequence of events). Secondly, the players' skill, strategic decisions, and knowledge of the games should make a difference. The longer the game, the more should skill contribute to victory. Thirdly, complex gameplay facilitated by many interactive parts and interweaving rules adds another layer of unpredictability and creates an opportunity for player skill and game knowledge to matter. The player is incentivized to learn to read and foresee the game

state and understand the strategic complexities to make judgement calls based on these observations. Most games combine these three sources of creating engagement – chance, player choices, and complex rules [1].

The game design in this thesis aims to create a more complex combat experience with less abstractions, where the player can make meaningful choices about where to attack an enemy to cripple its capabilities based on the body part harm. This is the lens through which later sections examine existing implementations in games. While assessing, designing, and implementing these features, the goal is also to develop in-engine tools that would make creating such enemies more streamlined in Godot.

Simulating Harm and Injury

The implementation of injury depends on where the design lands on the spectrum between realism and abstraction for the sake of gameplay. One avenue would be to simulate the game character as a physics-based entity with detailed models of musculature. Injury would be detected precisely where a collision with a weapon happens, and articulated movement that uses the muscles in those parts disabled. However, the goal of this thesis is not to create a perfectly realistic body simulation, but to provide a framework and streamline creating enemies with targetable body parts that serve as prerequisites for enemy abilities, and making it publically available to Godot users.

2.2 Case Studies

This section examines the systems within games that implement a body part injury system and their approach to the design.

In Horizon Zero Dawn and Horizon Forbidden West, components and armor plates can be removed with high tear damage weapons, which deals little to no damage, but reveals weak points or disables attacks[1].

In Monster Hunter Wilds, removing body parts is a core part of the experience, gathering them as loot or removing the monsters' dangerous abilities. Different weapon types (slashing, blunt, ranged) deal increased damage to specific enemies' body parts. For example, slashing weapons deal extra damage to tails, while blunt weapons can stun, making the enemy roll on the ground for a period of time[2].

Dead Space has many enemies with weak spots, different for each enemy type. Attacking those parts can limit an enemy's attack or movement. Some enemies can have armor that protects their weak points, forcing the player to focus on another weak point or to change their position to access weak points hidden on the enemy's back. Enemies can also have weak points that are dangerous to the player, such as explosive sacks damaging the player when destroyed in close proximity, forcing another angle of strategy to the weak point system. The important aspect of this combat system is in how it enforces different strategies that the player needs to apply based on the enemy type's weak point effects[3].

Fallout offers a slow-motion targeting system that allows players to target specific body parts. Each body part has its own chance of being hit, modified by distance and cover.

[1] https://www.polygon.com/horizon-zero-dawn-guide-walkthrough/21357205/machines-fight-rockbreaker-behemoth-thunderjaw-stormbird-deathbringer-tallneck-corrupted-cauldron/

[2] https://www.polygon.com/monster-hunter-wilds-guide/528353/monster-tails-fangs-claws-horns-how-to-get-sever-cut-break/

[3] https://www.dualshockers.com/dead-space-remake-necromorph-weakness/



Figure 2.1: First row: Dead Space's necromorph enemies with harmable limbs highlighted red[7]. Second row, left to right: Fallout's V.A.T.S.[8]and Phoenix Point's free aim targeting[9].

The number of attacks a player can make is dependent on the player's action points and the weapon type. Body parts have a status that's separate from the target's overall health. A status bar can be worn down until empty, at which point the limb becomes crippled. Crippled limbs have effects like hindered movement, removing a robot's weaponized arm, or shooting an enemy's head (which in most cases kills them outright)[4].

In Xenoblade Chronicles X, the player can target appendages which have their own health pool, separate from the overall one. Destroying appendages disables certain attacks and lowers the enemy's defenses[5].

Phoenix Point's "free aim" combat allows the player to hit specific body parts based on projectile collisions. Each body part has their independed values (like health) and features. Disabling parts has various effects, such as hindering mobility, disabling the enemy's main weapon, or triggering a bleeding effect. Each part also has a different armor value which reduces damage[6].

[4] https://www.videogamer.com/guides/a-beginners-guide-to-combat-in-fallout-4/

[5] https://deltiasgaming.com/xenoblade-chronicles-x-combat-guide/

[6] https://www.rockpapershotgun.com/phoenix-point-free-aim-and-part-damage-guide-how-to-use-the-free-aiming-system-for-more-precise-shots

[7] Image taken from https://vulkk.com/2023/02/03/dead-space-remake-combat-tips-how-to-defeat-each-type-of-necromorph/.

[8] Image taken from https://www.thegamer.com/fallout-3-vats-bethesda-nearly-cut/.

[9] Image taken from https://www.rockpapershotgun.com/phoenix-point-free-aim-and-part-damage-guide-how-to-use-the-free-aiming-system-for-more-precise-shots.

Summary

Body parts most often have a feature bound to them – an ability (like a weapon attack), protection (armor that protects weak points or targetable body parts from being targeted), or mobility. Attacking such body parts hinders those features, e.g., slowing an enemy down or disabling an attack. Additionally, body parts may serve as weak points, granting the player an advantage when being hit in a particular way (like stunning enemies by hitting their heads with a blunt weapon in Monster Hunter Wilds).

There are also variable values that modify the way limbs take damage, such as a hit chance (Fallout) or armor that reduces damage taken (Phoenix Point).

The designs also aim for enemy variance that enforces different strategies to be employed by the player (like in Dead Space).

Game designs should also be mindful of not overwhelming the player. This can be solved by making combat systems more diegetic, meaning embedding mechanics into to the "narrative world" (the game world as perceived by the game characters). For example, whichever body part the player shoots, that part takes damage, as opposed to the player choosing from several invasive UI popups.

2.3 Locomotion

Locomotion is the problem of making game characters move. Often, it is not a single system, but an intertwining of AI, gameplay, physics, and animation systems [4, Chapter 25].

This thesis concerns itself mainly with enemy AI and animation. Inverse kinematics is used to make simulated movement look more natural, allowing for end effectors, such as feet, to be placed dynamically based on things like raycast collisions with the terrain mesh (see adjusted foot height in Figure 2.2). Inverse kinematics can also be used for attaching end effectors to a point on the ground, correctly aiming for a target, etc. This can prevent awkward inconsistencies like sliding walk animations or animations when reaching for an object is offset from the actual target due to a static animation.

The injury system has to be dynamic, adapting to whichever injuries are applied to the character's body. Hence procedural animation fits this goal of adaptibility well. Rather than traditional animation with preset model movements, procedural animation can account for and adapt to injuries on the run, and make for a more realistic and immersive interaction with the injured character.

Inverse Kinematics

Inverse kinematics is *the rotational and translational motion of points, bodies (objects) and systems of bodies (groups of objects) without consideration of what causes the motion or any reference to mass, force or torque* [2]. In short, it is about moving and rotating a chain of links to reach a specific point.

It had originally been used in robotics for moving arms to targets, but has also expanded into animation in computer graphics. In the latter field, it is very useful for animating *articulated figures* (figures with a specific, solid form like humans, animals, and generally creatures with limbs). These models are often complicated, and require efficient calculation of complex and multi-link models that can have specified constraints (e.g., a maximum angle that a link can turn by). The multi-link models of articulated figures in inverse kinematics



Figure 2.2: Dynamic foot placement using inverse kinematics (The Witcher 3).

are calculated using the positions of the model's joints, known as *end effectors* (often the end joints), their potential constraints, and the target positions to be reached [2].

A *model* is a series of *links* connected by *joints*. Joints are the main component allowing movement – their positions determine the positions and orientations of the links. Links are the "connective tissue" between joints and are defined by their length, shape, volume, and mass. A *posture* is the skeletal configuration of the figure and must most often satisfy constraints to adhere to realistic movement, such as the torque limitations of each joint or the links not intersecting with other models in their path. A skeletal configuration is usually separated into *chains*, standalone parts attached to a static point on the model (e.g., the limbs of animals and anthropomorphs). The chains usually work in a hierarchy, and the movement of one joint affects the movement of the ones before it [2]. An example model can be seen in Figure 2.3. The way the movements of joints affect each other is illustrated in Figure 2.4. The target is reachable in (b) and (c), while (d) showcases the attempt of the chain to reach an unreachable target. The specific way these links bend depends on the concrete inverse kinematics solver implementation.

Usage of Inverse Kinematics

Forward kinematics (traditional animation where known, predefined transformations are applied to the model) can fall short in situations where dynamic adjustment of the target locations may be needed, such as characters standing on slopes or an appandage reaching for a target that can be a variable distance or height away. The bending of the links (such as limbs) is dynamically calculated, making for more natural-looking and adaptive movement, which is a desirable trait for our dynamic body part injury system that needs to account for the injuries made.

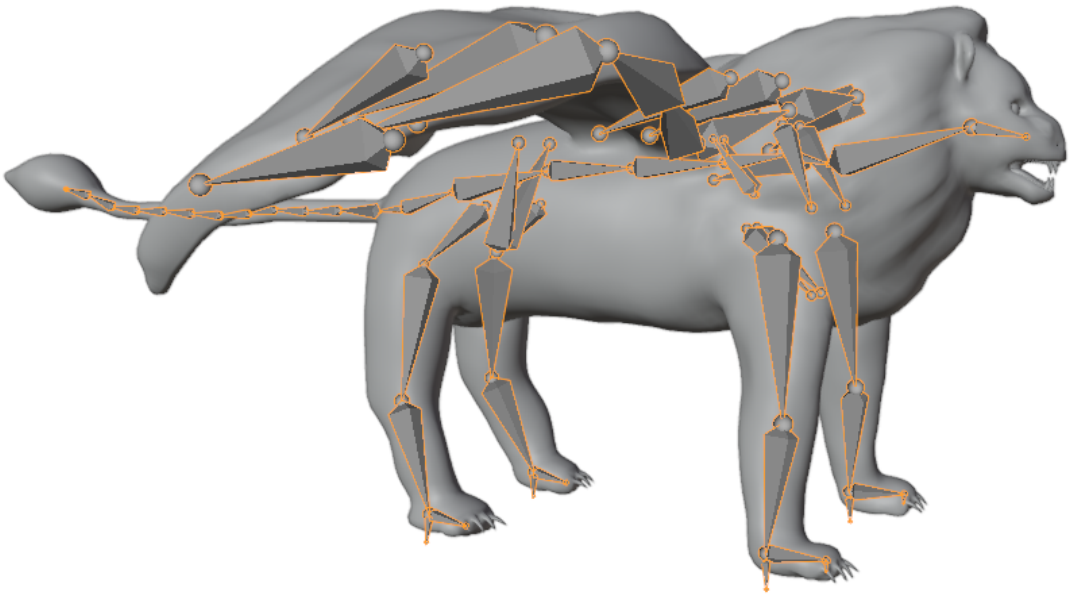


Figure 2.3: An inverse kinematics *model* – a skeleton rig of the game character consisting of *chains* like the limbs, the tail, or the wings.

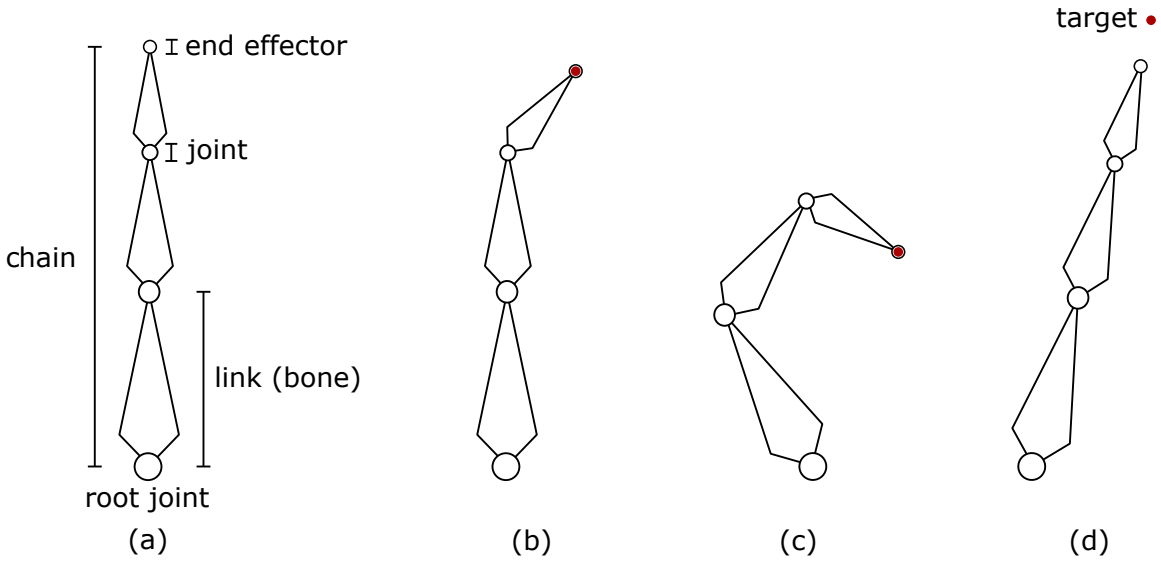


Figure 2.4: An inverse kinematics chain description and examples of the chain bending so that the end effector reaches the red dot target, showing two reachable and one unreachable target point positions.

2.4 Enemy AI

There are many ways to implement decision making in games. This section explains finite state machines, behavior trees, and utility theory.

2.4.1 Finite State Machine

One of the possible implementations of enemy AI is a finite state machine (FSM). FSMs are an architectural structure that can encapsulate enemy behavior into separate states, such as *Patrol* or *Attack*. A central directing *state machine* controls which state is active and allows for the state to be changed. The *state* itself has the encapsulated behavior logic (e.g., a patroling enemy walking between two points) and the transition logic like methods to be executed when entering or exiting a state [3]. A simple FSM implementation is illustrated in Figure 2.5.

Finite state machines are a quick and easy implementation of enemy AI where the behavior can be separated into states and where there are clear transitions in each state. It can get convoluted if the transition requirements are complex – in the most extreme cases, it would be FSMs where each state can transition to any other state.

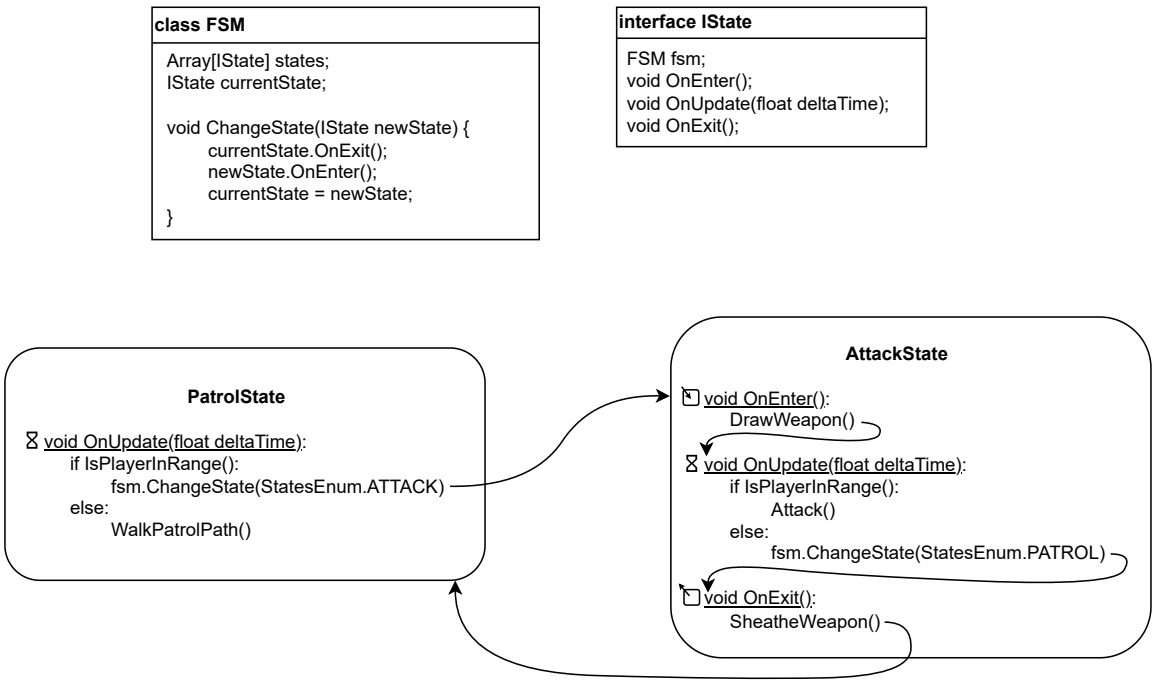


Figure 2.5: An example of a finite state machine implementing a simple enemy AI.

2.4.2 Behavior Tree

Another option for enemy AI implementation is the behavior tree (BT), a way to structure decision making logic into a more streamlined form. BTs follow the traditional node-based architecture of trees, but contain special node types that serve the node traversal and behavior logic. A sample BT and its traversal is illustrated in Figure 2.6.

The node type and implementation descriptions from this section are taken from [4, Chapter 6]. The most commonly used nodes are as follows:

- *Behavior* is an abstract interface that can be activated, run, and deactivated, and passes back a *return status*. The concrete implementations of this interface are *actions* (accessing information and making changes to the world) and *conditions* (a primary way of checking information from the world).
- *Sequences* can be thought of as sequential `AND` gates – each of their children nodes are executed in order one after another, until all have executed successfully or until one of the children fails. Not only is this useful for chaining behavior, but also for setting up conditions for whether to execute this branch at all – if a condition node is added as its first child, it must return `true` for the sequence to continue executing.
- *Selectors* can be thought of as sequential `OR` gates or fallbacks. It executes its children in order until one returns `SUCCESS` or `RUNNING`. If a child fails, the next one is its "fallback" behavior.
- *Parallels* execute all of their child nodes simultaneously. It is important to clearly define these nodes' return states (e.g., returns `SUCCESS` only if all of the child nodes succeed). When exiting, the termination of all child nodes must also be handled cleanly (although in some cases, like animations and sound effects, a delay in the child's terminatation to after it has finished its action may be desired).

Return statuses are crucial for tree traversal. Most often, behavior nodes return whether they completed their run as expected or not, or that they're still running – `SUCCESS`, `RUNNING`, or `FAILURE`. However, BTs can also leverage the return status for more efficient implementations, such as the `SUSPENDED` status code in event-driven BTs.

This basic BT implementation can then be extended by more specialized nodes.

- *Decorators* (named after the design pattern) allows behaviors to be wrapped in other behaviors, such as repeating a child's behavior n times.
- *Filters* will not execute its children under specific conditions (such as an action cooldown or a target being out of range of an action). Filters can be easily created by attaching a condition to the start of a sequence, as described above. Advanced filters can be created by combining sequence (`AND`), selector (`OR`), and condition nodes.
- *Monitors* serve for continously checking if assumptions for an active behavior are valid, and signal that the whole subtree should be exited when they become invalid. It runs in parallel with other nodes, usually a single sibling that is a behavior subtree that needs some continuous state checking (to ensure it makes sense to keep running it).
- *Active selectors* actively recheck their decisions regularly, allowing them to retry higher priority branches (e.g., interrupting a patrol with a search behavior if the player is spotted).

It is useful to have a `BehaviorTree` object that is built by a `BehaviorTreeBuilder`. This will serve as the central point for storing and updating the tree. The BT has an `update` method which performs the traversal of the tree and is the entry point of the BT. It is called whenever an update is needed, though it need not be every game frame – every other frame or 5 frames per second can suffice (to lighten or spread out the processing load). For a more efficient approach, an event-based node traversal implementation is possible where a central scheduler manages the traversal using the observer pattern.

Actions usually have to interact with other parts of the system. For this purpose, it can fetch data from a blackboard, a shared data storage for the behavior tree. It may also be important to have a shutdown mechanism that handles action exits cleanly [4, Chapter 6].

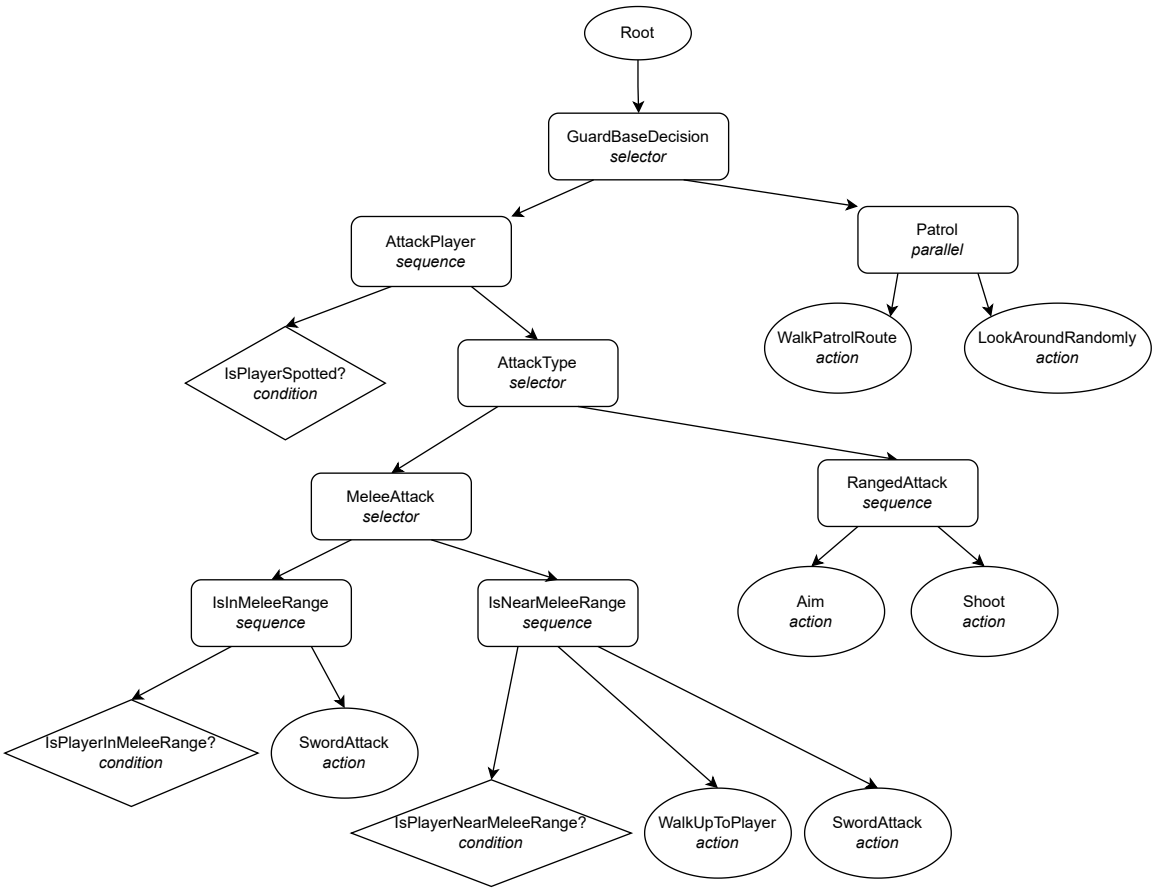


Figure 2.6: An example of an enemy AI behavior tree. A possible traversal in a situation where the player is not seen would go as described: The `GuardBaseDecision` seletor enters `AttackPlayer` (its first child). As a sequence, this node has to run all of its children in order to succeed. The `IsPlayerSpotted?` condition is false, and thus the whole sequence returns the `FAILURE` return state. The `GuardBaseDecision` selector then enters its next child (the fallback), which is a parallel node with two action children. The `WalkPatrolRoute` and the `LookAroundRandomly` actions start simultaneously executing.

2.4.3 Utility

Utility theory in enemy AI design refers to the evaluation of *utility* across multiple choices. Utility is the usefulness of the choice within the given context. The AI calculates a utility score for each action, and the action with the highest score is then chosen. The calculation of utility can be simple if the decision factors are comparable, like only taking into account a price of the same item from two sellers. However, more complex situation require the conversion and revaluation of values from one context to another, unified context. Utility scores should also be consistent and on the same scale, as they are directly compared to each other. Normalized utility scores are a good baseline for consistency [4, Chapter 9].

Utility calculations can also be integrated into behavior tree traversal. The behavior tree implementation can be extended by a *utility selector* node. It first queries its children for a utility score, and then decides which child to enter based on that score. For an AI aimed towards optimal decision making, the child with the highest score would be picked. Alternatively, the choice could be randomized, but still weighted towards the higher scored children [4, Chapter 10].

2.5 Godot

an overview of what it is and what it can do/what it offers since I'll be working in it

GDScript, C# some sources

2.5.1 Architecture

nodes, scene tree, in-engine tools, engine editor is itself a game, scripts can edit the editor and run directly within it

2.5.2 Shading Language

own shading language based of GLSL

Chapter 3

Injury System Design

The end goal of this thesis is to create a demo of an enemy system that allows players to target different body parts and destroy them to affect the behavior of the enemy. A secondary objective, though not any less important, is to build up supporting structures that help modularly construct different kinds of enemies in Godot.

3.1 The Modularity of Godot

Godot's scene and node-based architecture allows for great extensibility. Games in Godot are a tree of nodes that are grouped together into scenes[1]. It is possible to create classes by using `class_name` in the header of a script, which also makes them a custom node type that can be inserted into the scene tree, and they will work just like native node types (such as `CharacterBody3D`, `Camera3D`, `CollisionShape3D`, etc.). It is even possible to create tool scripts (by using the `@tool` header at the top of a script) which run live in the editor. The scripts' variables can be prepended with `@export` which makes the values visible and editable directly in the engine's editor. Their visibility can even be toggled or the possible values supplied based on the values of other variables. Via these engine features, Godot provides a toolbox for developing modular, extensible, and encapsulated systems that can then be woven together into a more complex scene.

3.2 Body Part Injury System

The goal is to recreate an injury system in Godot with nodes and tooling to facilitate creating enemies with body-part based models and abilities like in the video games in Chapter 2.

The player should be able to make meaningful choices that have a real impact on what happens next [5]. For example, a player that prefers melee combat might target an enemy's wings to prevent it from flying and getting out of melee range.

The game should combine the three sources of unpredictability mentioned in Chapter 2 to make it more engaging to players. The element of chance comes from the enemy's AI which makes randomized decisions based on a decision-making pattern like a behavior tree. The player chooses which body parts to attack so that they can disable the enemy's abilities that require those parts to be triggered. The complexity comes from the way body parts

[1] Overview of Godot's key concepts, available at https://docs.godotengine.org/en/stable/getting_started/introduction/key_concepts_overview.html

serve as prerequisites for the enemy's abilities, such as two wings being necessary for flight, at least three limbs for walking, or a stinger tail for poison attacks, and the way they enable and limit what actions it has available in its behavior.

There should be a central `Body` node that stores the total health, with `BodyPart` child nodes that either have their own health or subtract health from the `Body`.

losing a body part needs to have a gameplay effect (quote games)

Intertwined with the behavior tree of the enemy – altering the behavior based on destroyed boy parts – gameplay effect (e.g., fly attack is hard to avoid, so the player may want to focus on destroying the wings first to disable its fly ability). Such a system provides dynamic reactivity to the player's actions and choices.

Should also have visual effects as a visual response to the player's actions, while it also serves to make the core of the system – the dismemberment – look more impactful.

3.3 Enemy AI Based on Body Parts

3.3.1 Behavior Execution

what pattern to use when simulating the behavior? something that will change states like "Fly Up", "Descend", "Rake with Claws", but what will take care of the actual behavior? And what is the central brain that manages the state?

chosen Behavior Tree

The BT should have some sort of GUI to help streamline not only the creation of BTs, but also their fast editing and iteration. The node-based architecture of Godot is well-suited for the node-based structure of BTs, and thus the BT can live inside the enemy scene as a Root node and its collection of BT child nodes.

Event-based implementation via Godot's signals; construction on _ready() when the enemy node is loaded into the running scene

Nodes and decorators. All the classic ones for base functionality (tree traversal logic and execution nodes) – Root, Sequence, Selector, Action, Condition decorator.

PriorityReselctor – for interrupts when a branch with higher priority becomes available

Randomizer and WeightedRandomizer for pure randomization

UtilityRandomizer and Utility decorator – for circumstance-based calculated randomization

CooldownDecorator

Blackboard

3.3.2 Behavior Limiting

BodyPartFilter, BodyPartFilterRecheck

patterns to check for available actions? how to limit effectively what the Behavior Tree (or the chosen way to implement behavior) has access to? so that when the random value in the weighted network is generated, so that it does not try to execute a branch that cannot be executed due to missing links

The behavior also needs to be limited

deciding on actions and movement;

limiting options based on harm;

procedural animation of actions

3.4 Mesh Deformation

3.5 Demo Enemy Design

A manticore because it offers many opportunities for body part abilities and damage – legs, wings, stinger.

The body parts split into separate surfaces to be able to control their visuals separately and spawn meshes of the severed body parts

Animations for the various types of body-part based attacks and types of movement (the different missing body part types of movement especially)

3.6 Player Controller

Depending on the implementation of the player controller, there are even more elements of player choice and rules complexity. Such cases could include the player maneuvering around the virtual space to avoid or close in on an enemy, or any of the player's special abilities and attacks with various cooldowns and effects. However, the player controller is a complex issue of its own. It is not covered by this thesis, but the player's experience is a crucial aspect of games and should be accounted for when discussing game design.

A basic player controller for movement and camera (not the focus of this thesis despite having a crucial effect on gameplay in case of a full game).

3 types of attacks – slashing (arc), piercing (point), and bludgeoning (larger shape), each with their own models, hit effects and hit decals.

Chapter 4

Implementation and Demonstration

4.1 Modeling

Due to the unique requirements of the enemy model for this game demo, a custom model was designed and created. A simple arena-like desert basin surrounded by mountains was also modeled. Both models were made in Blender.

4.1.1 Enemy Model

The enemy model contains separate body part meshes, joined together as a cohesive whole. Each mesh has its own surface material as well, so that it can be controlled directly and in isolation from the other parts in the game engine.

First, a detailed model of a manticore was sculpted as a whole. Due to the high vertex count left after the sculpting workflow, the model was retopologized (simplified into fewer polygons) while maintaining the proper shape and details, but being more performance-efficient. The model was then UV-unwrapped (the vertices mapped onto a 2D image) and textured. Once the base model was finished, the skeleton rig was made using the Rigify Blender addon. Rigify's quadruped template with wing bones taken from the bird template was used. The rig was edited to fit the manticore, and some bones were added (such as the tail bones). Blender generated automatic weight paints (which determine how much a bone deforms the mesh), although they had to be manually adjusted in some areas.

Finally, the model was separated into the different body parts that would be targetable by the player – the head and torso, the legs, the wings, and a stinger tail. The vertices were ripped at the seams and the left over holes filled with new geometry to seal them.

Animations were made in Blender using the skeleton rig's inverse kinematics to position the bones and deform the mesh and then capturing these positions in the keyframes of the animation. These animations were catered to the different usage of body parts for the various types of movement and attacks that the manticore enemy possesses. Movement animations include the idle animation, walking, running, running with a limp, crawling, walking on hind legs, leaping, flying, and diving. Attack animations include biting, raking with claws (left, right, or both), and a stinger tail attack.

The whole model then had its vertices painted, with the red channel signifying the deformation magnitude (see Section 4.3). Controlling the deformation magnitude in sensitive areas can be crucial to preventing the revealing of body part seams or extreme deformations



Figure 4.1: The manticore model with detached body parts, rendered with vertex colors.

where they are not desired. Notice the black vertex colors where the body parts separate in Figure 4.1.

4.1.2 Environment

A sandy desert basin arena was modeled to test the enemy behavior in. To avoid the visible repetition of the seamless textures applied to the terrain, two texture shaders were developed that reduce these pattern artifacts. For the sand, the same texture was mixed at a different scale and rotation, the results of which can be seen in Figure 4.2. The rotation calculation uses the standard 2D rotation matrix.

```
in: float scale_1, float scale_2, float angle_offset

void fragment() {
    vec4 albedo_1 = texture(texture_albedo, UV * scale_1);
    float angle = radians(angle_offset);
    vec2 centered_uv = UV - 0.5;
    vec2 rotated_uv = vec2(
        centered_uv.x * cos(angle) - centered_uv.y * sin(angle),
        centered_uv.x * sin(angle) + centered_uv.y * cos(angle)
    );
    vec4 albedo_2 = texture(texture_albedo, rotated_uv * scale_2);
    ALBEDO = mix(albedo_1, albedo_2, 0.5).rgb;
}
```

Algorithm 4.1: Sand shader – repeating the same texture with a different scale and rotation.

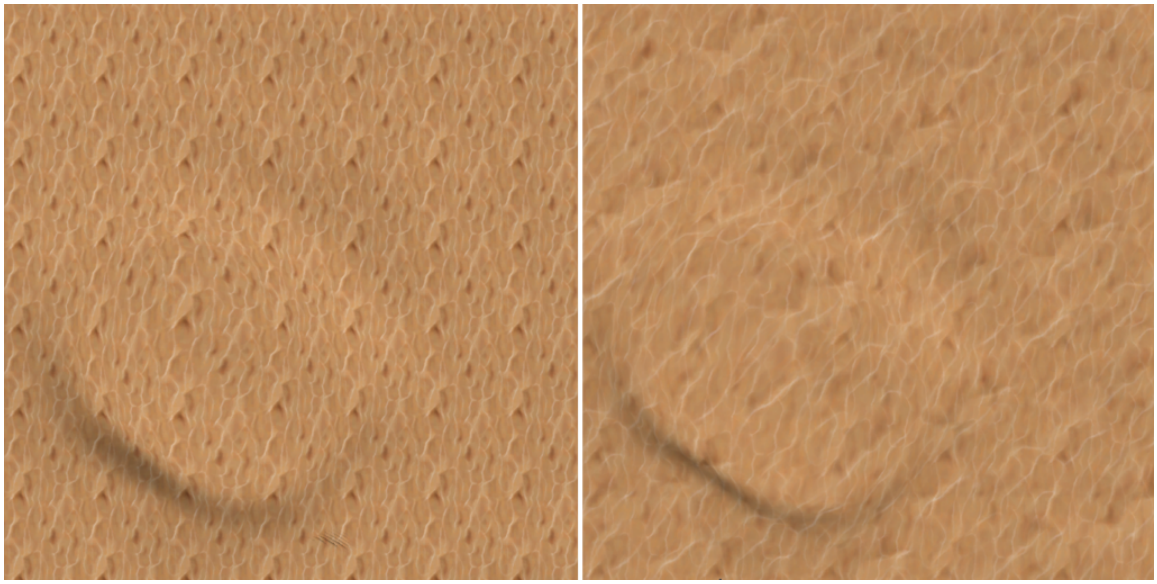


Figure 4.2: The sand environment – simple texture repetition (left) vs. shader (right).

A slight vertex displacement based on the height map texture of the sand was also added to the shader to roughen the unnaturally smooth ground mesh. The shader code in Algorithm 4.2 was shortened. The `rotated_uv` calculation is equal to the one in Algorithm 4.1, and the same scale and rotation is applied so that the height texture matches the albedo texture displacement.

```
in: sampler2D height_map, float max_height_offset

void vertex() {
    float height_1 = texture(height_map, UV * scale_1).r;
    height_1 = height_1 * 2.0 - 1.0; // normalize to -1 to 1
    float height_2 = texture(height_map, rotated_uv * scale_2).r;
    height_2 = height_2 * 2.0 - 1.0;
    float height = mix(height_1, height_2, 0.5);
    // move vertices up or down on the y axis
    VERTEX += vec3(0.0, 1.0, 0.0) * height * max_height_offset;
}
```

Algorithm 4.2: Sand shader – vertex displacement based on the height texture.

For the mountains, two different textures were mixed based on noise and slight color darkening, strongest at the transitions, was applied to further break up the monotony.

The shader mixes the two albedo textures based on the seamless noise texture. For the transition regions, we can figure out the extremes (values 0.0 being fully texture 1, or 1.0 being fully texture 2) by subtracting 0.5 from the noise texture, the values of which span 0 to 1. That maps the values to 0.0 (the transition point) to 0.5 (purely textured by one of the textures). Then we map it back to 0 to 1 by multiplying it by 2 and invert it to get the transition regions (with 0.0 being no transition), as seen in Algorithm 4.3.

```
in: float scale_1, float scale_2, sampler2D texture_albedo_2, sampler2D
    texture_normal_2, sampler2D noise, float noise_scale

void fragment() {
    float noise_value = texture(noise, base_uv * noise_scale).r;
    vec4 albedo_tex_1 = texture(texture_albedo, base_uv * scale_1);
    vec4 albedo_tex_2 = texture(texture_albedo_2, base_uv * scale_2);
    // mix the 2 albedo textures based on noise value
    vec3 mixed_albedo = mix(albedo_tex_1, albedo_tex_2, noise_value).rgb;
    // calculate transition regions
    transition = 1.0 - abs(noise_value - 0.5) * 2.0;
    // add some darkening along the transitions for more variation
    ALBEDO = mix(mixed_albedo, mixed_albedo * vec3(0.5), transition);
}
```

Algorithm 4.3: Rocks shader.

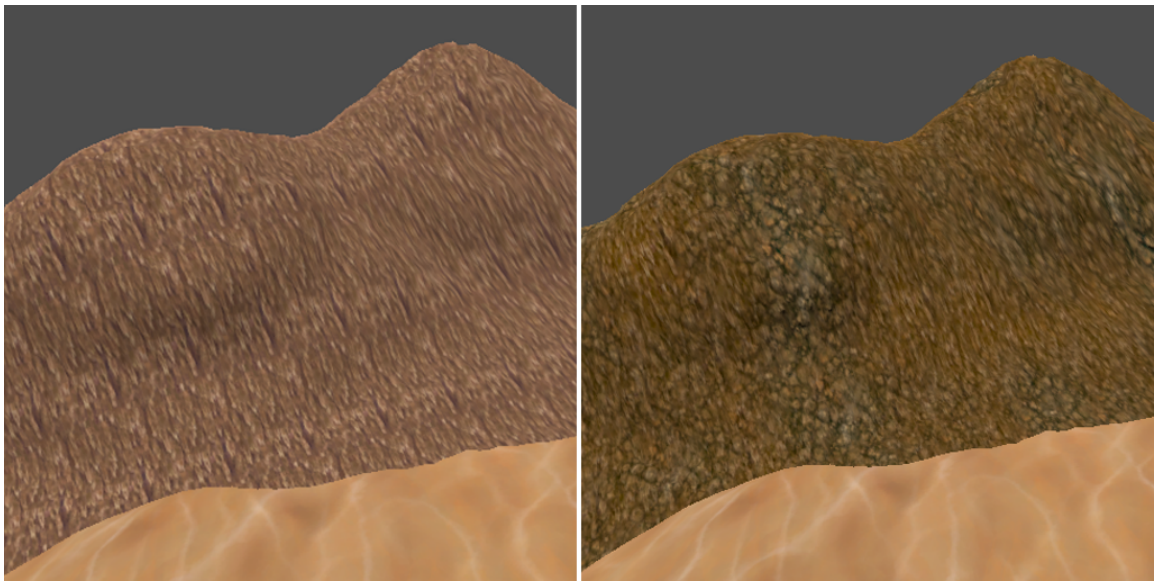


Figure 4.3: The rocks – simple texture repetition (left) vs. shader (right).

All environmental textures were taken from StylizedTextures[1]. The skybox was taken from FreeStylized[2]. Both websites offer their works under the CC0 license as of the writing of this thesis.

4.2 Behavior Tree

The behavior tree (BT) is the central control unit of the enemy AI. It decides the flow of the decision-making and and behavior execution via its node system. Each BT node inherits

[1]Stylized Sand 002, Stylized Rocks 001, Stylized Cliff Rock 006, available at: https://stylizedtextures.com

[2]Skybox 24, available at: https://freestylized.com

```
@abstract class_name BTNode

signal finished(status: ReturnStatus)

enum ReturnStatus { RUNNING, SUCCESS, FAILURE }

var blackboard: Blackboard
var child_nodes: Array[BTNode] = []

func construct_tree(bb: Blackboard) -> void:
	blackboard = bb
	var scene_child_nodes = get_children()
	add_children_and_call_their_construct()
	for child in child_nodes:
		child.finished.connect(_on_child_finished)

# to be overridden by subclasses
func _on_child_finished(_return_status: ReturnStatus) -> void:
	pass

# cleanup func for interruptable nodes; to be overridden by subclasses
func abort() -> void:
	pass

@abstract func execute() -> void
```

Algorithm 4.4: The `BTNode` class which all behavior tree nodes inherit from.

from the abstract class `BTNode`, the implementation of which can be seen in the pseudocode Algorithm 4.4.

When a behavior tree enters the scene tree (when it loads into the game), it automatically begins to construct itself, further described in Section BT.2. Each BT starts with the `BTRoot` node which also holds the `Blackboard`, starts the construction, and finally the execution, wherein each child node is executed sequentially no matter the return status.

It is also where the return status enumeration is defined. Currently, due to the event-based architecture, only `SUCCESS` and `FAILURE` are used, but `RUNNING` is also included should it ever be useful.

An event-driven behavior tree was implemented over a tick-based one (see Chapter 2). It allows the branches to manage their own uptime and just emit the `finished` signal when they're done, letting the parent nodes that are subscribed to that signal to handle the exit. Signals in Godot are equivalent to `events` in languages like `C#`.

To share information among the various branches, the BT uses a `Blackboard`, which is a dictionary that every BTNode has access to, initiated in the root and propagated to every node.

Each BTNode can also implement the `abort` function, which is used to interrupt currently running behavior. It is the responsibility of each node to correctly abort its currently running children. This abort logic has to propagate from the node that caused it all the

way through to the currently executed node farthest down the behavior tree, so any nodes that control the flow of the tree, as well as the decorators, must implement it.

The `BTDecorator` class that all decorator nodes inherit from is equal in functionality to `BTNode`, but allows only a single child node.

4.2.1 Node Types

This subsection describes the implementation of all the different behavior tree nodes.

Root

The root node is the first node of any behavior tree. It is responsible for the construction of the whole tree and the initialization of the blackboard. It executes its children sequentially, no matter the return state.

Sequence

The sequence node executes its children in order. If any of them finish with `FAILURE`, the whole sequence node finishes with `FAILURE`.

Selector

The selector node executes its children in order. If a child node finishes with `SUCCESS`, the whole selector node finishes with `SUCCESS`. Otherwise, it continues to the next child node. It returns `FAILURE` if none of the children succeed.

PriorityReselector

The priority reselector node acts like a selector node, but continuously (in the defined time interval) checks the availability of child nodes that are in the node tree before the one that is currently being executed. This rechecking only happens for child nodes that are `Condition` decorators (their condition is the one `PriorityReselector` checks against). In case a previous node becomes available (the condition result returns as true), the priority reselector aborts the current child and starts executing the newly available child.

For example, an `AttackOrIdleReslector` has a `Condition` child that checks if the player is seen by the enemy, and an `Action` node which performs the Idle behavior. Normally, the enemy executes the Idle action indefinitely, but when the player comes into the enemy's detection range, the priority reselector now evaluates the first `BTCondition` child as true, aborts Idle, and starts executing the attack branch.

Condition Decorator

The condition decorator executes its child node only if its condition evaluates as true. It contains a condition function, which is called whenever this node is executed. If it returns true, it executes its child and waits for its return status. If it returns false, the condition decorator finishes with `FAILURE`.

This can be used to filter out certain branches based on the given conditions and is generally useful in controlling the decisional flow of the tree traversal.

Randomizer, WeightedRandomizer, Weight Decorator

These nodes serve to randomize the flow of the behavior tree.

`Randomizer` is a pure randomization node. It randomly chooses which of its child nodes to execute.

`WeightedRandomizer` chooses a random child to executed based on the weights of the child. It expects the `Weight` decorators, which have a settable float `weight` property, as direct children; otherwise, the default weight is 1.0.

Both randomizer nodes account for body part filters, and do not consider branches that are filtered out due to missing body parts in the randomized child selection.

UtilityRandomizer, Utility

Utility randomizers work much like weighted randomizers, except the weights are dynamically calculated via utility functions that often use the variables of the current game state to evaluate which branch would be the most valuable to execute.

The randomization also heavily relies on the type of random number generator used. A generator with a continuous uniform distribution will maintain pretty even randomization. On the contrary, if a normal distribution were to be used, the randomization would be heavily skewed towards some of the choices. This might be desirable if the utility weights themselves are not sufficient in altering the probability towards choices with greater weights, and the developer wishes to further alter the probability scale. However, this project uses a continuous uniform distribution generator to preserve an even level of randomness of the chosen branches.

Utility calculations can bring out the most dynamic behavior in enemy AI, as they directly work with the state of the game to calculate the usefulness of a branch. It mainly depends on the complexity of the calculations and the game state variables taken into account.

Cooldown Decorator

The cooldown decorator only executes its child when the cooldown is available. Once the child node is executed, a cooldown timer is started, for the duration of which the decorator finishes with `FAILURE`. Once the timer runs out, the child can be normally executed again.

BodyPartFilter, BodyPartFilterRecheck

The body part filters are decorators that filter out branches where body parts are unavailable due to having been destroyed. It has an array of all required body parts and an array of body parts where at least one is needed to not be filtered. When executed, the decorator finishes with `FAILURE` if any body part is unavailable, otherwise it normally executes the child node. The BodyPart class is described in Section 4.4.

`BodyPartFilter` is appropriate for one-and-done checks, while `BodyPartFilterRecheck` is better for branches where the executing behavior lasts for a longer period of time. Since it continuously checks the available limbs and aborts and finishes with a `FAILURE` when a body part becomes unavailable, it is useful for detecting injuries in the middle of action execution.

Action

Action nodes are leaf nodes for the standard behavior execution. This is where the code for the behavior that the player sees lives, such as pursuing or a bite attack.

Blackboard

The blackboard is a shared data storage that every behavior tree node has access to. It is implemented as a dictionary with the `store`, `read`, and `remove` functions that work with keys and values of the `Variant` type (meaning any type can be used).

4.2.2 Creating Behavior Trees inside the Scene Tree

Developing a behavior tree only via code can be confusing and unweildy. Having a graphic representation in which they can be edited can bring clarity to their structure (since the parent-child hierarchy is clearly visible) and make their creation and iteration faster.

Godot's node architecture is well-suited for this purpose. Adding behavior tree nodes to the scene tree can be an intuitive way of construction. Behavior tree nodes can be created by defining their scripts as classes with `class_name` at the top – they automatically become nodes that can be added to the scene tree. Each node must then have an implementation of the construct function (obtaining the children from the scene tree and calling the construct function for each of its children) and a unified interface that can be relied on when driving the flow of the behavior tree (such as the execute and abort functions). When the enemy is loaded into the scene, the `Root` node gets all of its children from the scene tree and starts the behavior tree construction. Once that is finished, it starts executing the behavior tree, so the enemy AI starts immediately. The root is also where any starting variables should be added to the blackboard.

This way, the behavior tree structure can be constructed inside the editor. Each node can then be extended with a script that defines the necessary behavior (such as adding a condition function to the `Condition` decorator or attack logic to an `Action` node).

For visual clarity, svg icons were created to differentiate the node types at first glance, as can be seen in Figure 4.4.

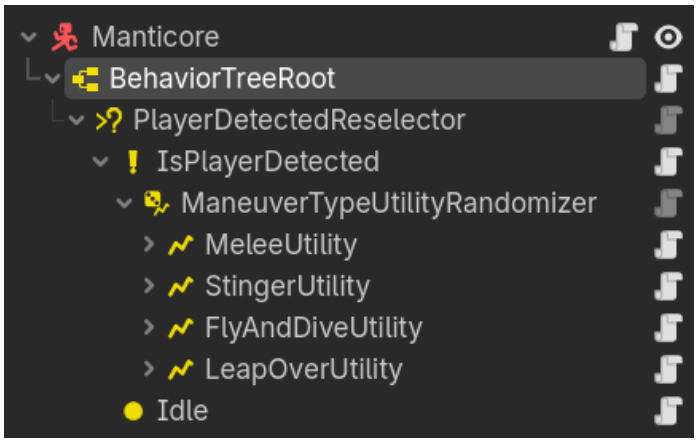


Figure 4.4: The behvaior tree nodes inside the enemy scene tree.

4.3 Deformation Shader

- talk about attempts to map it to UV, but unsuccessful. An ideal deformation would be painted directly onto the material, would also produce more stable results (when the same place is hit several time, the dent increases unnaturally) and would avoid the „only x hits“ array size issue.

- updated every frame with the new transforms (due to bone movements, the positions of the hits need to be recalculated)

- shader pro deformaci a flash efekt při zásahu

Similar to the concept of weight paints (which modify how much a given bone deforms the mesh when using a skeleton rig).

- deformation strength vertex colors due to controlling deformation in sensitive areas (insert photo of the manticore's deformed face with bulging eyes and teeth) – we do not want this kind of deformation, so we need to control the deformation magnitude in different parts of the body;

vertex modifier due to the necessity to author the deformation on different parts of the mesh – an equal magnitude of mesh deformation is not desired in all parts of the mesh; granular control via vertex colors offers a more authored enemy design, and prevents awkward deformations in sensitive areas, as can be seen in Figure x.



Figure 4.5: The same magnitude of deformation on the whole mesh can produce undesirable results.

4.4 Body Part Nodes

The logic for the separated body parts is contained within the `Body`, `BodyPart`, and `Hitbox` classes. Each class has a custom node icon.

Like the behavior tree nodes, these classes are also meant to be added to the scene tree (see Section 4.2.2), with `Body` being the root node and `BodyParts` being their direct children. `BodyPart` nodes should then contain `BoneAttachment3D` nodes (that copy the

```
in: int hit_count = 0, vec3 hit_positions[16], vec3 hit_normals[16], float
    hit_radius[16], float hit_strength[16]

void vertex() {
    float deformation_magnitude = COLOR.r; // vertex color
    for (int i = 0; i < hit_count; i++) {
        float radius = hit_radius[i];
        float strength = hit_strength[i];
        float dist = distance(VERTEX, hit_positions[i]);
        if (dist < radius) {
            float falloff = 1.0 - (dist / radius);
            falloff = falloff * falloff; // smooth
            VERTEX -= normalize(hit_normals[i]) * falloff * strength *
                deformation_magnitude;
        }
    }
}
```

Algorithm 4.5: Deformation shader.

transforms of the defined bone onto their children, making them move with the bone) with `Hitboxes` that contain the desired collision shapes. An example chain of nodes would be:
`Body -> LegFL (BodyPart) -> ThighFLBone (BoneAttachment3D) ->`
`-> ThighFLHitbox (Hitbox) -> CollisionShape3D`

There can be several `BoneAttachment3D` nodes, each with their own `Hitbox`, to detect hits more accurately (since collision shapes are usually simple shapes like capsules).

4.4.1 Health Management

The `Body` class tracks the central amount of health the enemy has, which determines whether it is alive or dead. `BodyParts` have their separate health pools, which determine whether that body part is destroyed or not, but they also have an option to make damage bypass their own health and only damage the central health pool. That option is useful for body parts that themselves cannot be destroyed, but contribute to the overall defeating of the enemy, such as the torso and head.

When a body part reaches 0 health, a notifying signal is emitted. A special camera effect plays and time slows down (described in Section 4.6), the separated mesh turns red for a moment and then the mesh is hidden, the bones and hitboxes freed, and a severed body part scene is spawned in the destroyed part's location with its own physics.

When the body reaches 0 health, a notifying signal is emitted, the behavior tree is stopped, and the ragdoll is activated (further described in Section 4.7.3). After a moment, the manticore's body fades into full transparency and is freed.

4.4.2 Hitboxes and Hit Management

`Hitbox` nodes inherit from `Area3D` nodes, which are able to detect when another area or body (like a projectile) collides with it. The hitboxes receive the hits with parameters wrapped in a `ProjectileHitData` resource. It contains `damage_amount`, `world_position`,

`world_normal`, `projectile_direction`, `decal_params`, and `deformation_params`. The world position and normal of the detected hit are then converted to the local space of the bone that the hitbox is attached to. Then the hitbox emits a signal with the original parameters, except with the world-space hit position and normal replaced for the converted ones.

`BodyPart` nodes are connected to this signal and whenever it is emitted, they start processing the hit. The global `enemy_hit` signal is emitted. Damage is applied to the body part (based on the hit's `damage_amount` parameter), the body part's flash effect is played, and the hit decal is added to the body part (both described in Section 4.4.3). If the body part has a knockback node attached, it applies the knockback using the `projectile_direction` vector (see Section 4.5). Finally, the hits are registered into the deformation arrays that are supplied to the deformation shader (see Setion 4.3).

4.4.3 Hit Effects

When the body part is hit, the flash effect is achieved via simple fragment shader code that controls the material's `emission`, interpolating between 0 and the flash strength, and back to 0.

Hit decals are spawned, attaching a `Decal` node oriented by the hit's normal to the `BoneAttachment3D` parent of the hitbox that was hit. These nodes project textures onto surfaces that they intersect with, hence why it is important to size and orient the node correctly.

When a body part is destroyed, it starts a constant spewing of blood particles. The particles themselves, implemented via the `GPUParticles3D` node, and a custom blood texture are spawned at a predetermined position and rotation on the enemy's body, activated by a `BodyPart`'s `body_part_destroyed` signal. The blood material's properties are set to `transparency: alpha scissor`, which, in combination with alpha curves that control the transparency of the material over time, makes it look like the blood congeales into separate strands as the alpha value decreases.

4.5 Knockback `SkeletonModifier3D`

The skeleton has a custom `BodyPartKnockback3D` node attached to it. The class inherits from `SkeletonModifier3D`, which allows developers to modify skeleton deformations via code. It applies bone modifiactions after animations (if an `AnimationMixer` is present), and they can even be stacked to modify the skeleton one after another as necessary.

Each `BodyPart` can have a custom `BoneKnockback3D` class node. It takes the bone to apply knockback to and the strength of the knockback as parameters. The `apply_knockback` function is called from `BodyPart` whenever a hit is received. `BoneKnockback3D` then converts the world-space projectile direction into the skeleton's local space, as that's the coordinate system that `SkeletonModifier3D` works with. The bone to apply knockback to, the direction, and the strength are then sent to the `BodyPartKnockback3D` node to be added to the ongoing knockback effects.

In `BodyPartKnockback3D`, the new knockback is added to the `active_knockbacks` dictionary where each entry is tied to a bone index key and contains the target offset, the current progress, and a bool flag signifying whether it is getting to the target offset or returning back to a zero offset. It also adds a knockback to the base bone of the whole

body (usually the base of the spine chain), which is defined as an export variable in the class.

The `_process_modification_with_delta` function from `SkeletonModifier3D` is used to process the knockbacks. Inside it, the active knockbacks are iterated through and their progress towards their target offsets is advanced by the defined speed. The current offset is applied on top of the skeleton's animations as an interpolation between a zero vector and the target offset based on the current progress (0.0 to 1.0). Once a target offset is reached, the `is_returning` flag is switched on and the progress is interpolated back towards a zero vector. After it raches progress 0.0, it is removed from `active_knockbacks` entirely.

4.6 Player Controller

The player controller implements a simple movement script from Godot's `CharacterBody3D` template. The player can choose between 3 types of attacks by pressing `1`, `2`, or `3`.

Each projectile has several export variables that can be set. The projectile's type can be slashing (a wide arc), piercing (a point), and bludgeoning (a sphere). This affects the way it detects hits. Slashing projectiles project a number of raycasts along its width, and the middle raycast's hit is preferred. Piercing projectiles have a single raycast from their center. Bludgeoning projectiles use a shapecast (an analogue to a raycast, but uses a shape instead of a line). Each hit's position and normal is recorded and handed off to the `Hitbox` that was hit. Next, the projectile's damage amount and travel speed can be set, as well as whether it should be affected by gravity. Each also contains decal parameters that are to be spawned on impact and attached to the enemy (see Section 4.4.3), impact visual effects (the projectile's break effect and blood particles that are spawned on a hit), and deformation parameters (see Section 4.3). For example, the boulder attack is affected by gravity, deforms the enemy's mesh, leaves a bruise decal, and spawns rock fragments and dust particles on impact.

When a body part is destroyed, the player is notified via the `body_part_destroyed` global signal. The time scale of the game is momentarily lowered so that it slows down, and the player camera zooms in.

When the player hits an enemy, an X-shaped crosshair appears to communicate the hit to the player. When the player is hit by an enemy, a blood texture flashes on the edges of the screen. Numerical damage to the player was not implemented, as it is not the focus of this thesis.

4.7 The Manticore Enemy

4.7.1 Body Parts

- the Body and BodyParts node structure, hitboxes, etc.
  - attacks and movesets, their body part dependencies

4.7.2 Behavior Tree

- the final BT implementation with all the nodes showcased/used
  - highlight adaptability (idle vs attack recheck; pursue fallbacks with active rechecking of body part filters)

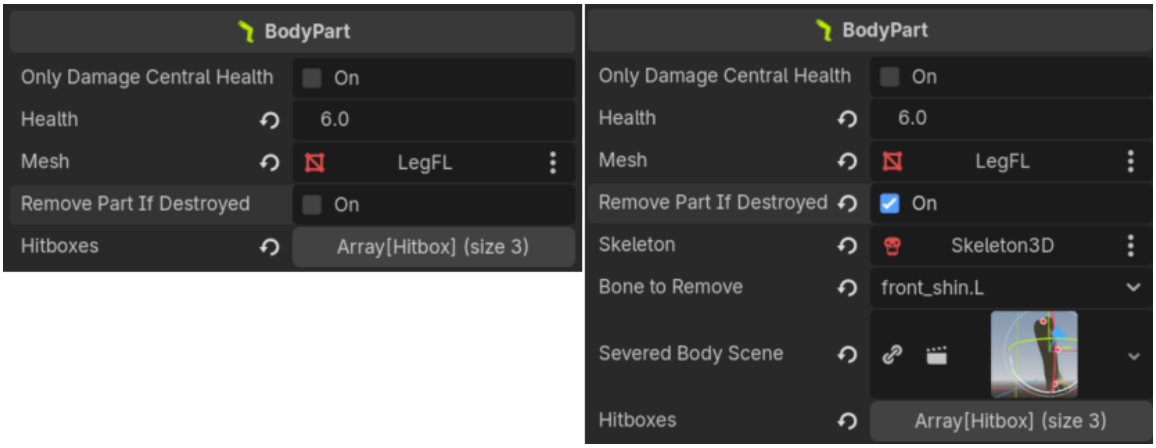


Figure 4.6: The export variables are being shown or hidden in the Godot editor depending on `remove_part_if_destroyed`'s value.

- demo behavior tree s Idle stavem a větví pro útočení; adaptivní pohyb při zranění během pronásledování (chybějící část potřebná pro daný pohyb je zaregistrována a přepne se na fallback pursue behavior)

4.7.3 Visuals, Adjustments, and Effects

- animation tree and controls

- slow down and zoom in on body part destroyed, crosshair effect on enemy hit (global `enemy_hit` signal)

- otáčení modelu dle úhlu země

- efekty při pohybování se a dopadu na zem (sand particles), efekty při zásahu (blood spray, hit decals), kontinuální blood spray při odseknutí končetiny

- ragdoll, 6DOF joints

- IK pro umístění nohou, řízeno přes keyframes animace (v momentu animace, kdy se noha usadí na zem - spuštění IK připevnění, obdobně při vznesení nohy a odpoutání IK) - WIP

- Editor enhancement: exports are shown/hidden based on conditions; skeleton bone options supplied after skeleton is loaded

4.8 Demonstration in Various Test Cases/Situations

like even a different model, like a robotic capsule, to showcase the deformation

Chapter 5

User/Performance testing of the resulting implemented design

Shader Precompilation - lag spikes whenever a new effect is on screen, like a new projectile or the manticore body transparency triggered - loading screen while all of the effects are played in the background to „precompile“ the shaders

Godot profiler

Number of detached limbs on the ground (physics test)

Too many deformation points and decals (like an enemy having 200 deformation marks, what's the performance stats on that – for 8, 16, 32, 64, 128, 256 marks scale graph info)

blackboard dictionary lookups testing?

Chapter 6

Documentation and Publication

Bibliography

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